

Available automation software

Agilent VEE. Agilent VEE (Visual Engineering Environment) is a high-level object-based dataflow graphical programming software for automated test, measurement, data analysis and reporting. It is designed to work seamlessly with T&M instruments and comes packed with all the desired features for an educational lab station, such as ease of connection to various software and hardware devices from multiple vendors, data manipulation and display utilities, runtime deployment capability and built-in MATLAB, Microsoft Excel and database integration engines.

VEE is finding increased acceptance in the education sector in India due to the ease in instrument programming and provides the right platform for students to learn test automation prior to entering the industry. To know more about Agilent VEE, visit www.agilent.com/find/vee

National Instruments' LabVIEW. LabVIEW is a graphical programming environment used by millions of engineers and scientists to develop sophisticated measurement, test and control systems using intuitive graphical icons and wires that resemble a flow-chart. It offers integration with thousands of hardware devices. Also, it provides hundreds of built-in libraries for advanced analysis and data visualisation—all for creating virtual instrumentation. To know more about NI LabVIEW, visit www.ni.com/labview

tions. Both IIVI-COM and IIVI-C consist of a set of instrument classes and provide instrument interchangeability independent of the instrument vendor.

Plug-and-play drivers, such as VXIplug&play and LabVIEW's proprietary Plug and Play drivers, specify

common sub-routines to access an instrument via a programming language.

If an instrument driver is not available, or is not required, you can directly connect and control instruments using Direct I/O method as well. Direct I/O uses specific instruction

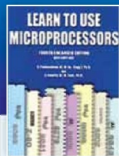
commands (called SCPI (Standard Commands for Programmable Instrumentation)) to directly communicate with the instrument and, in many cases, it is proven to deliver better performance than instrument drivers.

To complete the software component requirement, an input/output (I/O) software is required. Virtual Instrument Software Architecture (VISA) was created by the IIVI Foundation to standardise I/O software across physical interfaces and instrument vendors. VISA I/O software uses common terminology and syntax to connect and control instruments. A VISA library supports complete control of instruments across the physical interfaces of GPIB, USB, Ethernet, RS-232 and VXI. I/O software include such utilities as configuration of hardware, connection and control GUI, bus monitoring and troubleshooting.

Choosing the best combination of the three software sub-components

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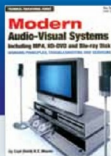
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